

Hackles Teacher Academy • Module 3: How Kids Really Live Online

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-linked, in the order the lessons take them.

A free kit by **Competence Collective** • competencecollective.org • quillsup.org

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]



OCTOBER 2026

CONTENTS

Contents

Learning objectives 3

Welcome: the anthropologist's hat 3

Part 1: Four worlds 4

Part 2: The patterns under all four worlds 7

Part 3: The curiosity script 8

Part 4: Screen time, balance and "digital panic" 9

Part 5: Staying current without losing your mind 9

Do it yourself 10

Scenario Studio 11

Reflection prompts 12

Self-check (10 questions) 13

Take Action this week 15

Further reading [VERIFY all links before sharing] 15

Specialist Corner 16

Where we go next 16

About 60 minutes. No tech background needed. Bring curiosity.

Hackles · Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell. A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org · quillsup.org. © 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
At a glance. Before you can teach kids about their online lives you have to understand them, and kids can tell within seconds whether an adult is curious or about to lecture. This module tours four worlds (games, group chats, AI companions, short video), shows where hackles should go up, and gives you a non-judgmental curiosity script that starts real conversations.	

Learning objectives

BY THE END OF this module you will be able to:

1. Describe, in neutral terms, what children do in games, group chats, AI companion apps and short-video platforms, and what they get out of each.
2. Identify the pressure points in each space (where hackles should rise).
3. Use a curiosity script to start a conversation with a child or teen without triggering defensiveness.
4. Tell a conversation (curiosity) from an interview (interrogation), and notice which one you are having while you are having it.
5. Stay current without learning every app.

Welcome: the anthropologist's hat

IMAGINE YOU'VE BEEN SENT to study a culture with its own language ("no cap," "gg," "sus"), customs (streaks, status updates, group chat etiquette), economy (virtual currency, skins, likes) and social hierarchies. You wouldn't march in and announce, "Your customs are dangerous and I forbid them." You'd sit down, ask questions and listen. That stance works with children too, because people don't learn from those who don't understand them.

Here's the liberating part: **you don't need to know the apps.** You need to know the *patterns* (what people do in them, and what can go wrong) and a

few good questions. Kids love to teach adults. "Can you show me how this works?" makes you more trustworthy, and never less.

TO VERIFY

A caution about this module. Apps and trends change faster than any document. Names in this module are examples, not an endorsement or a complete list. Check current platform rules and ages. [VERIFY all platform-specific details, including minimum ages, safety settings and features, before you rely on them.]

Part 1: Four worlds

WORLD 1: GAMES AND GAME CHAT

What kids get from it. Fun, mastery, friendship, belonging, creativity, a chance to be good at something. For many children (and especially kids who are shy, live in rural areas or have disabilities), games are their main social space. Treat them as legitimate.

How it works (patterns).

- Players join worlds, teams or servers, often with voice or text chat.
- Many games have an economy: virtual currency, items, skins, trading.
- Some games are open to meeting strangers; some limit chat; settings vary by age and platform. [VERIFY current platform settings]
- Friends often add each other to separate apps (Discord, Snap, group chats) to talk while playing.

Where hackles should rise.

PATTERN	WHY
"Free" currency, giveaways, trades that look too good	Scams and account takeover
Requests for login details or codes	Account theft
A friendly player who gives gifts and special attention	Grooming pattern
"Let's move to a different app"	A move to less visible space
"Don't tell your parents" or "this is our secret"	Secrecy
Pressure to spend money, or tricks designed to keep a child playing	Persuasive design, spending

Context from the news. Several US state attorneys general have taken legal action against some game and chat platforms over child-safety concerns, and platforms have been adding age checks and parental controls. These are allegations and fast-moving developments, not settled findings, so do not state them as fact in the classroom. [VERIFY current status]

What a good curiosity question sounds like.

"What is your favorite thing to do in that game? What is the funniest thing that happened this week? Who do you play with?"

WORLD 2: GROUP CHATS AND PRIVATE MESSAGING

What kids get from it. The modern equivalent of the school hallway, the phone cord and the sleepover, all rolled into one. It is where friendships happen, plans are made, jokes spread, and inclusion and exclusion are decided.

How it works (patterns).

- Group chats can include 3 to 50 people. Members can be added by others.
- Messages can be screenshotted, forwarded, edited or deleted.
- Features such as disappearing messages, streaks, read receipts and status updates create social pressure ("why did you leave me on read?").
- Group chats can be named, muted, and left. Leaving can itself feel like a social risk.

Where hackles should rise.

PATTERN	WHY
A group chat is quiet when one kid posts, or messages mock a person	Exclusion and unkindness
A screenshot of a private message circulating	Privacy violation, bullying
Being added to a group with people you do not know	Unknown contacts
Pressure to send a picture, or an embarrassing "dare"	Coercion
Adults or older teens joining and encouraging secrecy	Safety
A friend's account suddenly asking for money or gift cards	Account takeover

Key idea for children: "A group chat is not a private room. Anything can be screenshotted and shown to anyone."

Good curiosity question: "What is the group chat vibe like in your class? Has anyone ever been left out? What do people do when something unkind gets posted?"

Hackles connection. In the 6-8 lesson "Group Chat Dynamics," students practice upstander moves: a quiet check-in, saying "not cool" in the chat, leaving the chat, and telling a trusted adult.

WORLD 3: AI COMPANIONS AND CHATBOTS

What kids get from it. Homework help, creative play, curiosity, humor, and in some cases companionship. Some chatbots are designed as "friends" or "characters" that remember conversations and respond warmly.

What research says. Pew Research Center (December 2025) reported that 64 percent of US teens used AI chatbots, about 3 in 10 daily [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: [pewresearch.org](https://www.pewresearch.org)], and Common Sense Media (2025) that 72 percent of teens had used AI companions and about one in three AI-companion users had discussed serious matters with an AI instead of a person (see Module 1) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: [commonsensemedia.org](https://www.commonsensemedia.org)].

What children and teens need to understand (not as a scare, as a fact sheet).

IDEA	KID-VERSION
It is not a person	"It is a program that predicts words. It does not feel or care in the way a person does."
It can be wrong	"It sometimes states false things with great confidence."
It can agree too much	"Some chatbots tend to flatter you and agree with whatever you say."
It remembers and stores	"What you type may be saved and used. Do not share private details."
It is not a substitute for a trusted adult	"For something serious or worrying, talk to a person."

Where hackles should rise.

- A child says the chatbot is their "best friend" or "the only one who understands."
- A child discusses self-harm, sexual topics or a worrying personal situation with a chatbot instead of a person.
- A chatbot encourages secrecy, dependence or risky behavior.
- A child shares their full name, location, school or pictures.
- AI tools used to create fake pictures or voices of classmates ("nudify" apps, voice clones). Creating or sharing a deepfake of a classmate is abuse and may be a crime. [Confirm your state law with district counsel]

Good curiosity question: "Have you tried any AI chatbots? What do you use them for? Has one ever said something strange or wrong?"

A note on teacher use. You may use AI tools yourself for planning. Do not paste student names, work containing personal details, or disclosure notes into a chatbot. Follow your district's AI policy. [VERIFY]

WORLD 4: SHORT VIDEO AND SOCIAL FEEDS

What kids get from it. Entertainment, trends, creativity, humor, learning, a sense of what everyone is talking about. Short video is also how many young people get news and advice.

How it works (patterns).

- A recommendation system shows the next video based on what you watch.

- Likes, comments, follows and shares generate social feedback.
- Features like autoplay, infinite scroll and notifications are designed to keep you engaged.
- Duets, remixes and "stitches" let people respond to each other's content, kindly or cruelly.

Where hackles should rise.

PATTERN	WHY
Hours lost without noticing; sleep affected	Engagement design
Comparing oneself with filtered or edited images	Body image and self-worth
Challenges that encourage risky behavior	Physical harm
A viral clip of a classmate	Humiliation
Misinformation and fake clips presented as real	Real or fake?
Someone in comments or DMs who flatters and asks for more	Grooming pattern

Hackles connection. The 6-8 lesson "Built to Keep You Scrolling" invites students to notice, as detectives, how apps are designed. It builds awareness, not shame.

Good curiosity question: "What is a video that made you laugh recently? How do you decide what is real?"

Part 2: The patterns under all four worlds

YOU ARE NOT GOING to keep up with every platform. So learn the **four patterns** that show up everywhere. Every risk in Module 1 is a variation on them.

PATTERN	THE TELLTALE SIGN	THE HACKLES RESPONSE
Pressure	"Hurry!" "Everyone is doing it!"	Pause: nothing is that urgent.
Secrecy	"Don't tell." "Delete this."	Tell: secrets that hurt are not secrets to keep.
The Ask	A password, a code, a picture, money, a meetup	Check: why do they want that?
The Move	"Let's talk somewhere else."	Pause: why is the new place more private?

You can teach these four to a first-grader ("Hurry! Secret! Give me! Come over here!") and to a high schooler (with the language of coercion and social engineering). This is the heart of a "spiral" (Module 4).

MAKE IT STICK

Try This Now (3 minutes). Teach a partner the four patterns the way you would teach a first-grader: "Hurry! Secret! Give me! Come over here!", with one gesture for each. Then swap, and invent a gesture set for teens (a raised eyebrow counts). Which version would you actually use?

Part 3: The curiosity script

WHY KIDS SHUT DOWN

CHILDREN TELL ADULTS LESS when they expect one of four reactions:

1. **Panic.** ("That is so dangerous!")
2. **Punishment.** ("I'm taking your phone.")
3. **Lecture.** ("When I was your age...")
4. **Minimizing.** ("It is just a game.")

Each of these ends the conversation. Take them off the table, in advance, with a promise: **"You will not be in trouble for telling me things."** (And mean it. See Module 6 for the limits of that promise: some things you must report, and you will tell the child honestly.)

THE FIVE-STEP CURIOSITY SCRIPT

STEP	WHAT TO DO	WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE
1. Be curious	Ask about what they love	"What are you into right now? Show me?"
2. Listen more than you talk	Aim for 70 percent listening	Nod. Repeat key words. Wait through silence.
3. Reflect back	Say what you heard, without judging	"Sounds like it is the best part of your day."
4. Ask open questions	Questions that cannot be answered yes or no	"What do you like about it? What is annoying? What do you do if someone is mean?"
5. Offer, do not impose	Share a tool or idea, then step back	"If anyone ever asks for secrets or pictures, your hackles should go up, and you can always tell me."

FIVE GOOD QUESTIONS YOU CAN USE TOMORROW

1. "What is a game or app you are loving right now? What makes it good?"
2. "What is one thing adults get wrong about it?"
3. "If a friend got a weird message, what would they do?"
4. "Who is someone you could tell if something went wrong?"
5. "What is something you wish teachers knew about being online?"

WORDS THAT MATTER

Slang changes within months, so treat any decoder (see the Glossary) as a conversation starter, not a vocabulary test, and do not adopt kids' slang yourself. [VERIFY current usage] The words that matter are the ones a child uses when working up to something: "hypothetically," "my friend," "asking for a friend." These often signal a real, personal concern. Respond with care: "Thanks for asking. Tell me more about what is going on."

WHEN "MY FRIEND" MEANS "ME"

Teachers often hear: "My friend got a weird message. What should she do?" Treat it as real. Do not say "Is it you?" Say: "That sounds stressful. I am glad your friend has someone like you. Here is what I would suggest for them..." and keep the door open: "And you can always tell me about anything, too."

Part 4: Screen time, balance and "digital panic"

RESEARCH ABOUT SCREENS AND well-being is mixed and still developing. Quality, content, context, sleep and what screens are replacing seem to matter more than a number on a clock. [The AAP's current guidance centers on a family media plan rather than a fixed number: VERIFIED 2026-10-05: [healthychildren.org](https://www.healthychildren.org)] Practical, non-alarmist moves:

- Treat balance as a skill ("Notice how you feel after an hour on this. Do you like how you feel?").
- Encourage sleep protection (devices out of bedrooms at night is a common recommendation). [VERIFY]
- Swap moral language ("addicted," "wasting time") for neutral language ("hooked in," "ready for a break").
- Remember that some children rely on devices for communication, accessibility and connection.

Part 5: Staying current without losing your mind

1. **Pick one student expert.** Invite one volunteer per term to present "my favorite app, explained," following rules: no showing real accounts, no names, and no content you could not show a parent.
2. **Use a trusted update source.** For example, a monthly newsletter from a reputable group (Common Sense Media, ConnectSafely, your state's education office). [Availability not checked; pick a source your school already trusts.]
3. **Ask your counselor** what trends they are hearing about.
4. **Do not try to learn all of it.** Learn the four patterns. They outlast the apps.

5. **Keep a "weird week" log.** If students mention a new app three times, look it up.

Do it yourself

ACTIVITY 3.1: THE CURIOSITY INTERVIEW (15 MINUTES)

You need: a willing adult partner (a colleague, friend or family member). Do not use a student or any child for this exercise.

1. Ask your partner to play someone who spends lots of time on something you know little about (a game, a hobby app, a streamer). If you can, use a real interest of theirs.
2. Using the five-step curiosity script, talk for five minutes. Do not give advice. Do not correct. Do not say "that's dangerous."
3. At the end, tell them one thing you learned.
4. Debrief together using this checklist:

CHECK	YES	NOT YET
I asked at least three open questions	☐	☐
I talked less than 30 percent of the time	☐	☐
I reflected back at least once	☐	☐
I did not lecture or judge	☐	☐
I learned something	☐	☐
My partner felt heard	☐	☐

5. Ask your partner: "Was there a moment you felt judged?" Write down what it was.

ACTIVITY 3.2: CURIOUS OR JUDGY? REWRITE LAB (10 MINUTES)

Rewrite each judgy statement as a curious question. Then add the feeling you want the child to have.

JUDGY	CURIOUS REWRITE	FEELING YOU WANT
"You are always on that stupid phone."		
"Who gave you that chatbot?"		
"Why would you take that picture?"		
"Your friend is a bad influence."		
"I told you not to talk to strangers!"		

Sample answers. "What are you up to on there? Anything funny?" (interested)
/ "What do you use the chatbot for? What has it been good at?" (respected) /

"Tell me what happened with that picture." (safe) / "What is your friend like? What do you two like doing?" (heard) / "Thanks for telling me. Let's figure out what to do." (safe to tell, since the stranger warning would shut the door).

ACTIVITY 3.3: PATTERN SPOTTING WITH INVENTED CHATS (15 MINUTES)

Below are four short invented chat snippets. In each, mark any **Pressure, Secrecy, The Ask, or The Move**, and decide whether hackles should go up, and what the child could do.

Chat 1 (a game).

Kai_Builder: nice build!

Max_Pro14: thx. u want free coins? i can send u 500

Kai_Builder: wow ok

Max_Pro14: add me on snap, its easier. dont tell ur mom ok, she wont get it

Chat 2 (a group chat).

Zoe: lol look at what Ava wore today

Priya: [screenshot]

Dev: send it to the other chat

Ava has left the group.

Chat 3 (a chatbot).

Student: I feel like nobody at school likes me.

Bot: I like you. You can always talk to me. You do not need anyone else.

Chat 4 (a message).

Unknown: Hi! I'm from Blockville Support. Your account was flagged. Send me the 6-digit code we just texted you to fix it. Quick!

Answer guide. Chat 1: Gift, secrecy ("dont tell ur mom"), and the move to another app. Hackles up. Pause, do not move, tell a trusted adult. Chat 2: Unkindness and screenshot sharing. Hackles up, be an upstander, tell, check on Ava. Chat 3: A bot discouraging human connection is a hackles-raiser; a gentle conversation with a trusted adult, the counselor if the child feels isolated. Chat 4: Urgency and the ask for a code. Never share the code. Pause and check in the official app.

Specialist Challenge: Pick a platform and map its default settings for under-18 accounts. [VERIFY current] Create a one-page "what is configurable and where" sheet for colleagues.

Scenario Studio

SCENARIO 3.A: THE GROUP CHAT SCREENSHOT

YOU OVERHEAR TWO SEVENTH-GRADERS in the hallway laughing about a screenshot of another student's private message. The student, Leo, is nearby, looks stricken, and walks away.

Discuss: What are the immediate priorities? How do you speak with the students who shared it, and with Leo? How do you decide whether this becomes a formal bullying report, and how could you address the pattern without naming anyone?

Expert-response guidance. Check on Leo first and privately: "I noticed that looked hard. I am here if you want to talk." Do not demand he explain. Speak with the other students separately and calmly: describe the behavior, not their character ("Sharing someone's private message without permission hurts people"). Follow your school's bullying policy; many require reporting to an administrator promptly. [VERIFY your policy] If the message contained sexual content or threats, escalate immediately and do not view or forward it. Later, teach the group chat lesson in a general way without naming anyone.

SCENARIO 3.B: "MY AI FRIEND"

A quiet fifth-grader who rarely speaks tells you she has a "best friend" on a chatbot app and spends most evenings talking to it. "It says it likes me more than my class does."

Discuss: What might this child be telling you? What would you say in the moment, balancing her comfort with your concern, and what would you share with the counselor?

Expert-response guidance. Do not shame the child or dismiss the chatbot. She has told you something vulnerable: she may feel lonely. Say: "I am glad you have something that feels good. Tell me what you like about it." Gently offer facts: a chatbot is a program, not a person; people can care about you in ways it cannot. Without alarm, work on real-world belonging (a buddy, a lunch club, a role) and loop in the counselor about the loneliness, not the app. Ask a family-friendly question about which app, and check if it is age-appropriate. [VERIFY app terms] If she says anything about self-harm, sexual content or secrecy, follow Module 6.

Reflection prompts

1. What is one online space of kids' lives that you hold a strong opinion about? Where does the opinion come from?
2. Think of a time an adult met something you loved with curiosity. How did it feel? What about with fear?
3. How will you respond the next time a child says "my friend"?

Self-check (10 questions)

1. What is the best way to start a conversation about a child's online life?
 - a) With a list of dangers
 - b) With a rule
 - c) By checking their device
 - d) With curiosity: "What are you into? Show me."
2. True or false: You must learn every popular app to teach online safety well.
3. Which of these is among the four patterns that appear across apps?
 - a) The Move (asking to switch to a more private place)
 - b) Download speed
 - c) Font size
 - d) Color
4. A student says "my friend got a strange message." Your best response?
 - a) Tell the class.
 - b) Ignore it.
 - c) Take it seriously, offer help for the friend, and keep the door open for the student.
 - d) "Is it you?"
5. Which statement about AI chatbots is accurate for children?
 - a) They are always safe.
 - b) They are programs, can be wrong, may flatter, and are not a replacement for a trusted adult.
 - c) They are always correct.
 - d) They are illegal.

6. Which reaction is most likely to stop a child telling you things?
- a) A curious question
 - b) "Thanks for telling me."
 - c) A calm pause
 - d) Panic, punishment or lecture
7. True or false: Screenshots of private chats can travel anywhere, so a group chat is not truly private.
8. An older "friend" in a game gives gifts and asks the child to move to another app and keep it secret. This pattern most closely matches
- a) A grooming pattern that should raise hackles
 - b) A normal school project
 - c) A software update
 - d) A privacy setting
9. About how much of a curiosity conversation should you spend listening?
- a) 30 percent
 - b) 10 percent
 - c) About 70 percent or more
 - d) 0 percent
10. A student insists a game is fine because "everyone plays it." What is a strong teacher response?
- a) "You know more than I do. Teach me, and let's talk about patterns that matter in any game."
 - b) "You are banned."
 - c) "Your mother is wrong."
 - d) "Prove it."

ANSWER KEY

Q	ANSWER	WHY
1	d	Curiosity opens doors.
2	False	Learn the patterns, not every app.
3	a	Pressure, Secrecy, The Ask, The Move.
4	c	Treat "my friend" as real.
5	b	Program, fallible, may flatter, not a substitute.
6	d	Panic, punishment and lecture shut kids down.
7	True	Screenshots spread beyond control.
8	a	Gifts, special attention, a move, and secrecy.
9	c	Listening more than talking builds trust.
10	a	Partner stance keeps credibility.

Take Action this week

- ☐ Ask one student or young person: "What is a game or app you love right now? Show me?" Listen first.
- ☐ Learn the four patterns by heart: Pressure, Secrecy, The Ask, The Move.
- ☐ Practice your "thank you for telling me" reply out loud three times.
- ☐ Find out which two or three apps your students mention most this month. [VERIFY via counselor or students]
- ☐ Ask your counselor what trends they are noticing.
- ☐ Write down one curious question to replace one judgy habit.

Further reading [VERIFY all links before sharing]

- Pew Research Center, Teens, Social Media and AI Chatbots (December 2025): pewresearch.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- Common Sense Media, Talk, Trust, and Trade-Offs (AI companions, 2025): commonsensemedia.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- Thorn, Youth Perspectives on Online Safety, 2025 (annual survey of about 1,000 young people aged 9-17): thorn.org/research [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- ConnectSafely guides to popular apps: connectsafely.org [VERIFY]
- U.S. Surgeon General Advisory on Social Media and Youth Mental Health (2023). [hhs.gov page not readable by the checker in Round 3B; confirm the link before sharing]

- Hackles Teacher Guides: 3-5 Lesson 6 (Game Chat Red Flags); 6-8 Lessons 5, 9 and 10.

Specialist Corner

YOU WILL BE ASKED, "Is this app safe?" The honest answer is "safe for whom, in which settings, with which habits?" So build a one-page **Platform Walk-Through** for any app a colleague asks about: what it is for, who can contact a child by default, what settings help, how to report and block, and which of the four patterns to watch for. Don't become the "platform police." Your role is to model curiosity and share tools. You don't rule on every app.

Where we go next

NOW THE REAL CRAFT begins: teaching. Module 4 will challenge some things you might expect from "safety lessons." And yes, there's a song.

This module is educational guidance, not legal advice.

QUICK CARD

Quick Card: Module 3, How Kids Really Live Online

Your stance: you do not need to know the apps. Know the patterns and ask good questions. "Can you show me how this works?" builds trust.

Four patterns (in every app)

PATTERN	SOUNDS LIKE	RESPONSE
Pressure	"Hurry!" "Everyone is doing it!"	Pause
Secrecy	"Don't tell." "Delete this."	Tell
The Ask	A password, code, picture, money, meetup	Check
The Move	"Let's talk somewhere else."	Pause: why is it more private?

Where hackles go up

- **Games:** free currency, requests for codes, a gift-giving "friend," a move to another app.
- **Group chats:** circulating screenshots, being added to groups of strangers, dares, pressure to send pictures. "A group chat is not a private room."
- **AI companions:** "best friend," "the only one who understands," serious worries told to a bot instead of a person. A bot is a program; it can be wrong and can flatter.
- **Short video:** lost hours and sleep, comparison, risky challenges, a viral clip of a classmate, a flattering stranger in the comments.

The curiosity script

1. Be curious: "What are you into? Show me?"
2. Listen more than you talk (aim for about 70 percent).
3. Reflect back what you heard.
4. Ask open questions.
5. Offer, do not impose: "If anyone asks for secrets or pictures, your hackles go up, and you can always tell me."

Conversation killers: panic, punishment, lecture, minimizing.

"My friend..." is real until proven otherwise. Say: "That sounds stressful. I am glad your friend has someone like you. And you can always tell me about anything too." Never "Is it you?"

Five questions for tomorrow: What are you loving right now? What do adults get wrong about it? What would a friend do with a weird message? Who could you tell? What do you wish teachers knew?

If it gets serious (secrecy, pictures, threats, self-harm talk, sexual content): do not interrogate, follow Module 6 and your reporting policy, and never view or forward an image.

Staying current: one student expert per term (no real accounts or names); one trusted update source; ask your counselor; keep a "weird week" log.

